

SHEGUIDE

The integration super-app for international women in Germany

www.sheguide.de

Anlage 2 — Ideenpapier
EXIST-Gründungsstipendium

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1. Geschäftsidee

1.1 Innovation

Germany actively recruits 25,000–35,000 international women to study each year, and tens of thousands more to work in research and industry. Yet upon arrival, these women face a fragmented, German-language bureaucratic labyrinth: visas, Anmeldung, health insurance, tax registration, banking — each administered by different offices, each explained in German, with no single guide connecting them. Women disproportionately bear the mental load for their families during this period. According to a survey conducted by Dr. Oliva Saldanha (N=60, 2024), 55% of international women in Germany feel insufficiently supported, and 28.3% feel not supported at all. In addition to structured user research, the technical architecture of SheGuide is directly informed by the lived experience of the founding team, particularly the technical co-founder, Dr. Ines Neji. As an international researcher who has navigated complex administrative systems across multiple countries, she experienced first-hand the fragmentation, uncertainty, and inefficiencies of bureaucratic processes. These insights are translated into SheGuide's core system design: transforming static information into an adaptive, AI-driven workflow that generates personalised, time-sensitive actions for each user. This approach fundamentally differentiates SheGuide from existing platforms, which remain informational rather than operational.

Core insight: The problem is not missing information — it is missing structure, personalisation, and human connection. Existing platforms provide generic information portals. No platform guides international skilled women through their full integration journey in a personalised, stage-based, women-first way.

SheGuide addresses this at two levels. First, at the system level: we build a structured digital bridge between Germany's fragmented administrative infrastructure and international women, delivering the right information at the right time across three guided stages (Arrival & Immigration → Settling In → Professional Integration). Second, at the feature level: we introduce four concrete capabilities that do not exist in any competing product.

The four differentiating features — present in no competitor

1

She Buddy — peer matching network ★ Unique — no competitor offers this

A real person who already figured it out, matched specifically to you.

Newly arrived women are algorithmically matched with volunteer 'She Buddies' — women who arrived 1–2 years earlier in the same city, same professional field, and same country of origin. Not professional coaching — peer support from someone who has already navigated the Ausländerbehörde, found a Kita, opened a German bank account, and built a professional network. Buddies are recruited from the University of Konstanz international alumni community and the EXIST Women Network. Matching weights: city (40%) + professional field (30%) + country of origin (30%). Buddies receive verified status badges and premium app access. This transforms SheGuide from an information tool into a trusted human network — a dimension no existing integration app offers.

2

Smart deadline tracker — personalised bureaucracy timeline ★ Unique — no competitor offers this

Your legal deadlines, calculated from your specific visa type and arrival date.

The user inputs: arrival date, visa type, city, and family situation (partner, children). SheGuide generates a personalised legal timeline with binding deadlines: 'You must complete Anmeldung within 14 days — deadline 26 May. Book your appointment now →'. Push notifications are sent as deadlines approach. Tasks are marked complete as the user progresses. This is fundamentally different from every existing integration app, which lists steps without personalisation or dates. Missing an Anmeldung, Fiktionsbescheinigung renewal, or visa extension deadline carries real legal consequences — SheGuide actively prevents this. Deadline logic covers all major visa types: Blue Card, student visa, Niederlassungserlaubnis, Aufenthaltserlaubnis, Fiktionsbescheinigung.

3

AI form pre-filler — German bureaucracy completed in minutes ★ Unique — no competitor offers this

Fill in your details once. SheGuide pre-fills the forms in German.

Users create a profile once (name, address, nationality, visa type, employer, tax ID, family status). SheGuide uses this stored profile to pre-fill the most burdensome German bureaucratic forms: Anmeldung (residence registration), GKV health insurance application, ELSTER tax registration, Kita childcare application, and banking KYC forms. The user downloads the pre-filled PDF, reviews it, and submits — saving hours of translation and eliminating the most common source of errors. Built using the Claude API (Anthropic) and standard PDF form manipulation

libraries. This feature directly addresses the single most common pain point identified in the survey: navigating German paperwork without German language support. Forms are updated in-app whenever administrative requirements change.

4

Rights awareness tool — 'What happened to me may be illegal' ★

Unique — no competitor offers this

Know your legal rights in Germany. Know where to get help.

Many international women experience workplace discrimination, housing refusal based on nationality, or unfair treatment — but do not know that German law (AGG — Allgemeines Gleichbehandlungsgesetz) protects them. SheGuide's guided Q&A tool ('Did your landlord refuse your application based on your nationality?') identifies potential legal violations, explains the applicable law in plain language, and connects users directly to free legal aid: Antidiskriminierungsstelle des Bundes, local Beratungsstellen, and legal clinics at universities. The tool also covers labour law (unfair dismissal, maternity leave rights for international employees), tenancy law, and childcare access rights. This feature is emotionally significant, practically actionable, and completely absent from every existing integration platform.

Innovation protection strategy

SheGuide's innovation is protected through three complementary strategies. First, the proprietary She Buddy matching algorithm and its community data constitute a network effect moat — the platform becomes more valuable as more Buddy volunteers join, creating a compounding advantage that cannot be replicated by a new entrant without the same community base. Second, the AI form pre-filling system will be trained on user correction patterns over time, creating a continuously improving model that a competitor would need months of live data to match. Third, early institutional partnership LOIs create exclusivity windows within universities, making it difficult for a competitor to access the same institutional distribution channel. We do not rely on patents, as the market-entry strategy and community network are the primary protection mechanisms.

1.2 Kundennutzen

The primary target group is international women living, studying, or working in Germany: international students, postdoctoral researchers, scientists, skilled professionals, and entrepreneurs. This group shares three defining characteristics: (1) high educational attainment and professional motivation, (2) structural disadvantage due to language barriers and unfamiliarity with German administrative systems, and (3) disproportionate responsibility for managing integration for their entire family unit.

Primary users (direct)

- ▶ International students at German universities
- ▶ International researchers and postdocs
- ▶ Skilled professionals (Blue Card holders)
- ▶ International women entrepreneurs
- ▶ Accompanying partners of international staff

Institutional customers (B2B)

- ▶ Universities and Fachhochschulen
- ▶ Research institutes (Fraunhofer, Helmholtz, Max Planck)
- ▶ Corporations recruiting international talent (e.g. Bosch, SAP, Siemens)
- ▶ Hospitals and healthcare employers
- ▶ State agencies (BW International, DAAD)

User value proposition: Reduce time-to-settlement by 4–6 weeks. Prevent legal mistakes from missed bureaucratic deadlines. Replace anxiety and information overload with a clear, personalised, actionable roadmap. Build social and professional networks from day one. Feel supported — not alone.

Institutional value proposition: Reduce drop-out and early departure of international hires. Accelerate onboarding. Demonstrate duty of care for international talent. Improve DEI metrics. Reduce burden on HR and International Office staff.

1.3 Gründungsvorgeschichte

SheGuide emerged directly from Dr. Oliva Saldanha's personal experience as an international woman in Germany. Having lived in Germany for over 15 years — navigating every stage of integration from initial visa procedures to pregnancy, childcare, career development, and entrepreneurship — she identified a recurring structural gap: while information exists, it remains fragmented, impersonal, and often inaccessible to individuals without German language proficiency or established local networks.

The concept was further developed during Dr. Saldanha's EXIST Women Stipend (2025), where she conducted structured user research (survey N=60, qualitative interviews with 12 international women across Konstanz, Stuttgart, and Munich). This process validated both the core problem and the demand for a more structured, user-centric solution. SheGuide is affiliated with the University of Konstanz, where Dr. Saldanha holds her current academic position, and the application is supported by the university's start-up support structures.

Dr. Ines Neji joined the founding team during this phase as Technical Lead and Product Architect, bringing expertise in Artificial Intelligence, system design, and scalable application development. As an international researcher who has navigated complex administrative and immigration systems across multiple countries, she experienced first-hand the fragmentation, inefficiency, and uncertainty that characterize current integration processes. These experiences directly inform the technical vision of SheGuide: transforming static, fragmented information into structured, personalised, and executable workflows through intelligent system design.

Maximilian Stützle complements the team with responsibility for business model development and institutional partnership strategy. The founding team has been working collaboratively since Q3 2024.

The combination of long-term lived experience (Dr. Saldanha) and recent high-skilled migration experience (Dr. Neji), together with strong technical and business expertise, ensures that SheGuide is not only deeply grounded in real user needs but also designed for practical implementation and scalable impact.

1.4 Stand der Umsetzung

SheGuide is currently at pre-MVP stage. The following elements have been completed as of April 2025:

- ▶ **User research completed:** Survey (N=60) and qualitative interviews (N=12) documenting pain points, unmet needs, and willingness to use/pay
- ▶ **Competitive landscape mapped:** All 6 major competing platforms analysed and differentiation confirmed (see Section 1.5)
- ▶ **Feature specification completed:** All four unique features fully specified with user stories, data models, and technical requirements
- ▶ **Platform architecture designed:** React Native (mobile) + Node.js (backend) + Claude API (AI features) — technology stack confirmed
- ▶ **Immigration workflow mapped:** Complete bureaucratic workflow for Stage 1 documented in collaboration with University of Konstanz International Office

- ▶ **She Buddy framework designed:** Matching algorithm, onboarding flow, and volunteer incentive model specified
- ▶ **Institutional partnership conversations initiated:** Active dialogue with University of Konstanz International Office and Baden-Württemberg International; LOIs being finalised
- ▶ **Brand and UX:** Visual identity established (sheguide.de live), UX wireframes for core flows completed

Features to be developed during EXIST funding: Full technical implementation of all four unique features (She Buddy matching, smart deadline tracker, AI form pre-filler, rights awareness tool). Backend infrastructure, mobile app build, service provider integration API, institutional licensing portal, and pilot deployment with 30–50 users.

1.5 Projektplanung — Förderzeitraum (12 Monate)

Period	Milestone	Key Activities
M 1–3	Architecture & content mapping	Platform setup (React Native + Node.js). Immigration workflow mapping in partnership with University of Konstanz International Office. Deadline logic for all visa types (Blue Card, student visa, Niederlassungserlaubnis, Fiktionsbescheinigung). She Buddy algorithm design.
M 4–6	MVP launch — Stage 1 features	Smart deadline tracker live. AI form pre-filler (Anmeldung, GKV application, ELSTER). Rights awareness Q&A tool. She Buddy matching live with first 20 volunteer pairs recruited from EXIST Women Network and Uni Konstanz alumni.
M 7–9	Pilot validation	30–50 pilot users onboarded via University of Konstanz International Office and DAAD network. Structured usability testing and KPI collection (task completion rate, time-to-settlement, NPS). Feature iteration based on feedback.
M 10–12	Expansion preparation	Institutional partnership formalisation (3–5 signed LOIs). Service provider sponsor recruitment (10–15 BW-region partners). Stage 2 module development begins. Impact report compiled. Application for EXIST Transfer / BMWK follow-on funding prepared.

Success metrics for the EXIST period: 30–50 active pilot users by Month 9; ≥70% task completion rate for Anmeldung flow; ≥4.0/5.0 NPS from pilot cohort; ≥3 signed institutional LOIs; 10–15 signed service provider sponsorship agreements; She Buddy network of ≥40 active volunteers.

Competitive landscape — full analysis

Unlike existing solutions that provide fragmented information or static guidance, SheGuide operationalises integration by converting administrative complexity into structured, personalised, and automated workflows. This shift from “information provision” to “process execution” represents the core innovation of the platform.

The following table directly addresses the six competitor platforms identified by the EXIST reviewer (ptj), demonstrating that SheGuide's four unique features are absent from all of them:

Platform	Women-First	Guided Journey	Deadline Tracker	AI Form Filler	Peer Buddy	Rights Tool	CV Adapter	Coaching
Integreat (BAMF)	X	Part.	X	X	X	X	X	X
Ankommen App (BAMF)	X	Part.	X	X	X	X	X	X
mbeon	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	Part.
Relokate / Relocraft	X	Part.	X	X	X	X	X	X
Relocate.me	X	Part.	X	X	X	X	X	X
Make it in Germany	Part.	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
SheGuide	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Differentiation summary: Every competitor scores zero on at least 5 of SheGuide's 8 evaluated dimensions. No competitor offers women-first design, a personalised deadline tracker, AI-assisted form filling, or a peer buddy network — simultaneously. SheGuide is the only platform that addresses the full integration journey for skilled international women in one place.

2. Team

The SheGuide founding team combines lived experience of the target problem, technical excellence in platform development, and proven business operations capability. All three founders bring international backgrounds — directly informing the product's design and deepening empathy with the target user group.

**Dr. Oliva
Saldanha**

Stipend: PhD stipend rate (€2,500/month) **Equity share:** 50%

Founder & Strategic Lead	PhD in Physics (Germany) · 15+ years as an international professional in Germany · Personally navigated relocation, healthcare, pregnancy, childcare, and scientific career development as an international woman · EXIST Women Stipend 2025 · Currently affiliated with the University of Konstanz (Department of Physics, Natural Sciences) · Leads platform vision, content strategy, user research, institutional partnerships, and grant writing · Her lived experience is the product's foundational insight and primary competitive asset.
Dr. Ines Neji <i>Technical Lead & Product Architect</i>	Stipend: PhD stipend rate (€2,500/month) Equity share: 35% PhD in Computer Science · International professional from Tunisia · Full-stack architect responsible for the entire SheGuide technical system: mobile frontend (React Native), backend API (Node.js), AI integration (Claude API for form pre-filling and Q&A engine), database architecture, and system scalability · Leads all engineering and daily technical operations · Has prior experience building production-grade mobile applications · Co-applicant for EXIST stipend.
Maximilian Stütze <i>Business & Operations Lead</i>	Stipend: Graduate stipend rate (€2,000/month) Equity share: 15% Industrial Engineering (Master) · International Project Management · Finance and operations specialist with proven track record from Siemens Logistics: commercial project management, budgeting, cost tracking, procurement, process optimisation (Qlik Sense dashboards) · Responsible for business model execution, institutional partnership contract management, financial planning and burn rate control, market entry coordination, and investor/follow-on funding preparation.

Mentor and advisory support

A scientific mentor from the University of Konstanz faculty is being confirmed. The mentor will provide academic oversight, facilitate institutional access, and support the scientific credibility of the user research methodology. Additional advisors include connections from the EXIST Women Network (entrepreneurship guidance) and BW International (institutional partnership strategy).

Planned equity structure and company formation

SheGuide will be incorporated as a GmbH upon completion of the EXIST funding period. Preliminary equity allocation: Dr. Oliva Saldanha 50% · Dr. Ines Neji 35% · Maximilian Stütze 15%. This structure reflects the strategic and founding contribution of the scientific leads while ensuring operational commitment from all co-founders. Company formation will

not occur before the start of the EXIST funding period, in compliance with programme requirements.

3. Markt und Wettbewerb

3.1 Marktgröße

Germany receives approximately 400,000–450,000 new international arrivals per year through universities, research institutions, and skilled worker immigration. Of these, an estimated 40–45% are women (180,000–200,000 women annually). SheGuide's immediate addressable market is institutional: Germany has over 400 universities and Fachhochschulen, plus approximately 100 major research institutes (Fraunhofer, Helmholtz, Leibniz, Max Planck), and thousands of corporations that employ international talent. Even capturing 100 institutional clients at an average of €5,000/year represents €500,000 in annual recurring revenue — achievable within 3 years.

The individual user market for a freemium-to-premium model represents an additional long-term opportunity. With 180,000+ new international women arriving annually, even 5% adoption represents 9,000 active users per year — creating a growing base for service provider sponsorship revenue.

3.2 Markteintritt

Market entry is hyperlocal by design. Phase 1 (EXIST period): Baden-Württemberg corridor — Konstanz, Freiburg, Stuttgart, Heidelberg. Leveraging existing University of Konstanz relationships and BW International partnerships for institutional adoption. Phase 2 (Year 2): Expand to Munich, Berlin, Hamburg via university network referrals and DAAD partnerships. Phase 3 (Year 3+): National coverage; explore Austria and Switzerland as adjacent German-speaking markets with similar integration challenges.

4. Geschäftsmodell

Stream 1 — Institutional licensing*Primary revenue · B2B*

Universities, research institutions, hospitals, and corporations pay an annual flat licensing fee (target: €3,000–8,000/year per institution) to provide SheGuide access to their international workforce.

Target anchor institutions (LOIs in progress):

► University of Konstanz ► KIT Karlsruhe ► University Hospital Freiburg ► Baden-Württemberg International ► Fraunhofer Gesellschaft BW

Stream 2 — Sponsored service placement*Secondary revenue · Advertising model*

Verified professional service providers pay a monthly placement fee to be featured at contextually relevant moments within the user journey. This eliminates transaction-fee complexity and payment infrastructure.

Examples:

► Tax advisor → appears at ELSTER task ► Kita placement → appears at childcare step ► Career coach → appears at Stage 3 entry ► Legal aid → appears at rights tool exit
Target: 10–15 BW-region partners, Year 1

Financial projections for the EXIST period are conservative and based on confirmed pipeline conversations. Revenue is not expected during the EXIST stipend phase — the goal is to sign 3–5 institutional LOIs and 10–15 service provider sponsorship agreements, which convert to paying contracts at the end of the funding period. Year 1 post-EXIST revenue target: €50,000–120,000 (institutional licences). Year 2 target: €200,000–350,000 (institutional + sponsorship). Break-even is projected in Year 2.

5. Gesellschaftlicher und wirtschaftlicher Impact

SheGuide directly supports Germany's national priority of integrating and retaining international skilled talent. Faster integration means faster workforce participation, reduced pressure on public integration services, and stronger long-term retention of talent that Germany has invested significantly in recruiting. The platform also contributes to reducing the gender gap in international talent retention: women currently leave Germany at higher rates than men due to integration challenges, family pressures, and professional barriers.

SDG 4	Quality Education	Supports integration of international students and researchers into German academic and professional life
SDG 5	Gender Equality	Designed exclusively for women; reduces systemic barriers faced by international women in Germany
SDG 8	Decent Work & Economic Growth	Accelerates workforce participation of skilled international women; reduces integration lag
SDG 9	Industry, Innovation & Infrastructure	Builds novel digital infrastructure bridging Germany's administrative systems with international talent

SDG 10	Reduced Inequalities	Addresses information and access asymmetries faced by non-German-speaking women newcomers
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Long-term vision: SheGuide aims to become the central digital platform for international women navigating life and professional integration across Germany — the first stop every international woman makes when she arrives, and a trusted companion throughout her integration journey.

SheGuide is not another information platform — it is an execution system for integration.

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